



ST. PIUS X CATHOLIC HIGH SCHOOL · MODEL UN CONFERENCE 2026

GENERAL ASSEMBLY 1

# Women's Rights Abuse in the Middle East

*"A More Equal Middle East Begins with  
Women's Rights"*

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AJ Ruiz & Victoria Alfonso-Perez, Chairs

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GA1/BG/2026

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# Letter from the Chairs

Esteemed delegates,

My name is Ana Julia Ruiz, or AJ for short, one of the chairs for the St. Pius X Catholic High School 2026 Model UN Conference. As your chair, I would like to give you a warm welcome to the committee and conference.

This is a very important conference for us here at St. Pius X, as it is our first time hosting a conference, and we are so excited to have you be a part of it. Hosting high schools from all over the metro Atlanta area is a wonderful opportunity for us to interact with our Model UN high school community in and around Atlanta.

For those of you who are participating in the Women's Rights Abuse in the Middle East committee, I would like to share a moving and powerful quote on the gravity of women's rights. "Just because you have rights today does not mean that you will have them tomorrow". Said by actress Sheryl Lee Ralph at the National Ally for Equality Award Gala in October 2022, as she won the prestigious award presented by the Human Rights Campaign.

Here in the United States, we can sometimes take for granted our rights to freedom. The focus of this committee is to find ways to bring equality to women a world across from us. This requires an abundance of empathy and sympathy, which can be lost when we don't feel or see the problems firsthand. Personally, this quote reminds me not to take for granted what we have, and it serves as a reminder of both how quickly things can change and calls us to advocate for those who can't.

As you prepare for this committee, I want to remind you of the most important thing you will get out of this: not just the chance to show off your collaboration and writing skills, or the awards, but the community and fun you will get out of this experience.

Once again, I'd like to welcome you and look forward to all that you will do. Good luck!

**AJ Ruiz**

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to General Assembly 1!

My name is Victoria, and I am one of your chairs for this year's conference. I am currently a junior at Pius, and I have been involved in Model UN since my freshman year. Over the past few years, I have had the opportunity to attend many conferences, take on different roles, and meet so many amazing people through MUN.

One of my favorite things about Model UN is how it pushes you to think critically, speak confidently, and understand perspectives different from your own. I also love the friendships and connections that come from being part of the MUN community. Whether you are completely new to MUN or have been doing it for years, I hope this committee gives you the opportunity to grow, challenge yourself, and have fun.

In General Assembly 1, we will be discussing women's rights across the Middle East. This is a topic I am especially passionate about because it allows us to explore important human rights issues while also understanding the unique historical, cultural, and political circumstances of different countries.

As you prepare for committee, I encourage you to research thoroughly, participate actively, and approach every perspective with an open mind. Most importantly, don't be afraid to speak up and get involved!

My co-chair and I are so excited to meet you all and see what you bring to the committee. Good luck, and see you in GA1!

**Victoria Alfonso-Perez**





The General Assembly Hall, United Nations Headquarters. Wikimedia Commons CC BY-SA 2.0

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## Introduction to the Topic

The struggle for gender equality worldwide is complex, especially in the Middle East. Women in this region of the world face systemic legal discrimination through family law, national rights, and male guardianship systems. Even with international efforts to advance women's rights, many countries continue to restrict women's autonomy and fail to protect women from violence. The international non-governmental organization (NGO), Human Rights Watch, found in a 2023 report that in 75 percent of countries in the Middle East, women can not leave their houses without permission from their husband or another male guardian. Fifteen out of twenty countries will penalize women for leaving their homes without permission.

**KEY TERM: MALE GUARDIANSHIP**

A legal and social system, present across much of the Middle East, under which a woman must obtain permission from a husband or other male relative for actions such as travel, marriage, or accessing housing.

If they were to get married and, for some reason, needed to get divorced and gain child custody, laws for them are also against them. Let's say the reason for divorce was domestic violence, like rape; in several nations marital rape is not criminalized; this reinforces male control over a woman in marriage. While there are existing rape laws, they fail to protect women because the laws are based on the use of force, threat, or coercion rather than the absence of freely given consent. Divorce laws are just as warped; men can unilaterally divorce and can claim most of the inheritance as theirs, and fathers are also favored in child custody disputes.

Now, this is only legal autonomy; physical autonomy comes with its own set of issues. Two years ago, Iranian authorities adopted a draconian veiling law. Veiling in the religious, specifically Islamic, context is a diverse practice of modest dress with head covering; the most widely known one is a hijab, a scarf that covers the head and neck while leaving the face completely clear. On December 13, 2024, the Iranian "Law on Protecting the Family through the Promotion of the Culture of Chastity and Hijab" went into effect.

This law permits the imposition of the death penalty for peaceful activism against Iran's discriminatory compulsory veiling laws. Drafted in response to the "Woman Life Freedom" uprising, this 74-article law codifies a suffocating system of gender persecution by imposing severe criminal penalties for defiance against compulsory veiling. Under its framework, women and girls face public flogging, steep financial fines, and long-term prison sentences for "bad dressing" or "unveiling," with peaceful advocacy against the law even carrying the threat of the death penalty. Beyond physical punishment, the state coordinates economic persecution by freezing civil rights, barring women from driving, renewing passports, or accessing bank accounts if fines go unpaid, while granting blanket legal impunity to vigilantes and security forces who violently attack non-compliant citizens. These actions have led the UN Fact-Finding Mission to designate Iran's systemic policing of women's bodies as a crime against humanity of persecution on the grounds of gender, highlighting how stripping individual bodily choice functions as an institutional tool to suppress broader political dissent.

Harmful physical altering practices are another persistent issue in these countries. Practices like female genital mutilation (FGM) and child marriage persist at high rates in specific countries across the Middle East. FGM has been documented to occur in Iran, Iraq, Jordan, Oman, Palestine, the United Arab Emirates, Yemen, and Sudan. FGM, formerly known by the inaccurate and misleading term "female circumcision," denotes the partial or total removal of external female genitalia for nonmedical reasons. In fact, the practice provides zero health benefits for women and a host of potential side effects, including bleeding, infection, urinary problems, psychological trauma, and complications during childbirth that can lead to the death of both mother and child. And despite claims to the contrary, no religious texts recommend the practice; rather, it is a cultural and social norm found in communities with conservative views on women, femininity, and modesty, views that are often defended by the claim that they are religiously prescribed. In 1993, it was recognized as a form of violence against women in the Declaration on the Elimination of Violence against Women. In Egypt, roughly 84% to 87% of women aged 15 to 49 have undergone this human rights violation.

Ongoing conflicts across nations like Syria, Yemen, Lebanon, and Gaza have disproportionately displaced millions of women and girls, destroying health infrastructure and escalating risks of sexual exploitation and hunger. Women's rights abuses in the Middle East matter globally because gender inequality directly undermines international security, economic stability, and human rights standards. Nations with severe gender discrimination are statistically more prone to civil conflict, state failure, and violent extremism, which threatens global peace.

Furthermore, excluding women from education and the workforce stunts regional GDP, crippling trade potential and straining international aid systems. The resulting systemic violence and lack of freedom also drive massive refugee crises that place humanitarian pressures on countries worldwide. Ultimately, allowing these violations to go unchecked erodes the authority of international human rights law everywhere.

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## Historical Background

The course of women's rights in the Middle East includes early constitutional progress, backlash, and now an effort for legal reforms amid ongoing conflict. From the 1930s to today, there have been many efforts and events relating to the struggle for rights. Turkey was a leading force in women's rights. On December 5, 1934, under former president Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, women were granted full suffrage, or voting rights. Not only were they granted the full right to vote, but also able to run in national elections. This right to vote and be represented would be reflected in the results of the 1935 elections, where eighteen women were elected to Turkey's parliament.

Fast forward twenty years later, the suffrage movement has spread to North Africa. Syria would soon follow, neighboring Turkey's led by Turkey, and granted women voting rights in 1949. This new freedom and representation in government would display just how active women would be in academic, political, and economic fields. Soon, bordering countries like Lebanon and Egypt would have these reforms. Lebanon's President Camille Chamoun granted the right to vote in 1953, and Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser in 1956.

In Iran, there began to be change in favor of women. Iranian Pahlavi dynasty passed a set of highly progressive laws, called the Family Protection Act of Iran, in 1975. This set of laws expanded women's rights in marriage, divorce, and child custody. It allowed women to seek a divorce, and if a divorce did happen and they had a child, custody would go to the mother unless courts decided otherwise.

Courts would now be a part of the divorce process as well, which abolished extrajudicial divorce. Another important article within the act was Article 16, which didn't let a man remarry until he got consent from his first wife and the courts; it was targeted at polygamy. Then came a violent upheaval, known as the Islamic Revolution of 1979. The Islamic Revolution undid years of progress for Iranian women. The new theocracy regressed progress by lowering the legal marriage age for girls to nine, brought back polygamy, and forced women to wear hijabs in public. This revolution stripped women of their newly earned independence and legally placed them under the strict control of male relatives.

Women in Saudi Arabia would face similar issues of male control, this time on the roads. In 1990, about 50 women protested the country's ban on women driving and drove a convoy of cars through the nation's capital, which, up until 2018, was illegal. These brave women were immediately arrested and faced social and professional backlash.

Following the turn of the century in 2005, Kuwait granted women full political rights, including suffrage and the ability to hold parliamentary office. Then came the 2011 to 2014 era known as the Arab Spring. The conservative Syrian government met pro-democracy protests in 2010 with brutal force, leading the country to enter into a civil war. These protests in Tunisia brought down a 23-year-old authoritarian government. Neighboring Egypt began to protest the 30-year control President Mubarak had, working with his regime, and handing power over to the military.



These events had mass participation by women activists. While it yielded mixed results, the period ignited legal pushback against structural violence, notably fueling the eventual repeal of "marry-your-rapist" loopholes in countries like Morocco, and later Tunisia, Jordan, and Lebanon.

In the following years, Saudi Arabia began to undergo progressive changes. First in 2018, when the kingdom lifted the female driving ban and allowed women over the age of 21 to travel and get passports independently. Unfortunately, the government detains and suppresses prominent women's rights activists. Recently, in 2022, the death of Mahsa Amini sparked nationwide protests and the "Women, Life, Freedom" movement in Iran. Mahsa Amini was arrested in Tehran for allegedly violating the country's veiling laws.

Iranian authorities claim that she suffered a heart attack, a stark contrast to the eyewitness report stating that she was beaten by police. Ultimately, Iranian authorities claimed she suffered a heart attack. However, a UN investigative probe and human rights groups found that she died as a result of physical violence and trauma from police officers.

The state has responded to the movement with deadly force, executions, and further tightening of hijab surveillance. Most recently, the three-year ongoing Israeli–Palestinian war has disproportionately affected women. There have been thousands of civilian women killed or displaced while caught in the crossfire of the conflict. Alongside an alarming collapse of reproductive and maternal healthcare infrastructure in conflict zones.



"Women, Life, Freedom" — the slogan of the movement that followed the 2022 death of Mahsa Amini in Iranian police custody. Wikimedia Commons CC BY-SA

## International legal frameworks

International human rights treaties provide the legal architecture for advancing gender equality, yet their execution across the Middle East highlights a persistent tension between global standards and state sovereignty. The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women in 1979 has been ratified by nearly every state in the region, with the notable exceptions of Iran and Sudan. However, the treaty's practical enforcement is severely weakened by sweeping national reservations placed on Articles 2 and 16, which mandate the elimination of discrimination in public policy and family law. Member States frequently argue that these provisions directly contradict domestic religious jurisprudence and Sharia-based personal status codes.

To address the vulnerability of women during geopolitical instability, the international community relies on UN Security Council Resolution 1325 happening at the turn of the century, which established the Women, Peace, and Security agenda.

This landmark framework legally binds member states to protect women from gender-based violence during armed conflict and mandates their inclusion in formal peace negotiations. Additionally, the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action of 1995 serves as a vital political blueprint, granting local civil society groups the leverage needed to safely lobby for domestic legislative updates. Collectively, these international agreements offer a robust toolkit for delegates, though bridging the gap between treaty ratification and local legal compliance remains a central challenge for the committee.

## **The United Nations' role**

The United Nations has deployed various human rights monitoring mechanisms, targeted funding, and peacekeeping mandates to address women's rights in the Middle East, though its structural efficacy remains bound by state sovereignty. Through the Human Rights Council, the UN frequently establishes independent fact-finding missions to investigate and document systematic gender-based violence in regional conflict zones.

While these field investigations successfully build authoritative legal records, they rarely result in immediate criminal accountability due to frequent geopolitical stalemates within the UN Security Council. On a grassroots level, UN Women operates via its Regional Office for the Arab States to actively fund local coalitions like the Hurra Coalition, which lobbies regional governments to reform patriarchal personal status laws. Furthermore, the UN has helped several states, including Iraq, Jordan, Lebanon, and Palestine, adopt National Action Plans under the Resolution 1325 framework to integrate women into state security sectors. Unfortunately, a chronic lack of state-backed funding means that under-resourced local NGOs frequently bear the practical burden of executing these peacebuilding initiatives. Ultimately, while UN agencies excel at setting normative standards and supporting local civil society, their institutional impact faces ongoing criticism for selective enforcement and an inability to enforce domestic compliance against uncooperative state regimes.

# Current Situation

Legal recognition of women's rights varies significantly by country due to differences in legal structures, politics, social values, and experiences of conflict. The main issues in 2026 include access to education and employment, equality before the law, political involvement, protection from violence, and access to economic assets. According to the World Bank's Women, Business, and the Law 2026 report, the Middle East is one of the regions with the biggest legal obstacles to the economic empowerment of women, despite certain measures being taken in some countries to expand women's employment, entrepreneurship, working conditions, and other economic rights.

In particular, an important point to consider is the difference between the legal guarantees and women's actual rights. The 2026 assessment by the World Bank pays attention not only to the legal framework but also to the set of institutions and policies that underpin the law and its enforcement. In general, women have two-thirds of the legal rights enjoyed by men. Additionally, legal measures that support women's economic activity are enforced only in half of the cases.



Conflict and political instability in part of the region continue to influence women's rights. On the one hand, conflicts may disrupt education, employment, health care, and access to essential services. On the other hand, increased migration, unemployment, and economic insecurity may reinforce preexisting inequality and hamper the efforts to reduce it. Economic disruptions caused by armed conflict may affect food and energy prices, the availability of jobs, and government spending on social services. Therefore, women's rights cannot be separated from regional security.

As UN Women points out, considerable progress was made in developing legislation and policies that protect women's and girls' rights, but there is still a huge discrepancy between the legal framework and women's reality.

Based on the assessment of progress since the 1995 Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action using national evaluations in 159 countries, there have been positive changes in terms of employment and involvement of women, but at the same time, gender discrimination remains deeply rooted in various social institutions. The distinction between legal equality and substantive equality is particularly important when analyzing women's rights. UN Women has highlighted that passing laws does not necessarily lead to their implementation. Structural inequalities, discriminatory social norms, violence, and lack of access to institutions prevent women from enjoying their rights. All these issues remain relevant for the Middle East region.

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## **Bloc Positions**

Countries approach women's rights in the Middle East differently depending on their political systems, regional alliances, religious and cultural traditions, and views on national sovereignty. Although most states formally support improving women's well-being, disagreements often emerge over how international organizations should address women's rights and how much authority individual governments should retain over domestic laws and policies.

### **Western Bloc**

The Western Bloc included the United States, Canada, the United Kingdom, France, Germany, and other European countries. Western countries generally emphasize women's rights as universal human rights and are more likely to support international monitoring, legal equality, protection from gender-based violence, political participation, and access to education and employment.

These countries may favor a stronger UN involvement when governments are accused of serious abuses. However, delegates should recognize that Western countries do not have identical policies, particularly concerning reproductive rights and immigration.

## **Middle Eastern and OIC states**

The Middle Eastern and OIC states include Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Jordan, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, etc. There is no single Middle Eastern Position. Many Governments support expanding women's education, employment, healthcare, and economic participation while also emphasizing religious traditions, cultural values, family structures, and national sovereignty.

Gulf states such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE have introduced significant reforms aimed at increasing women's economic participation, while maintaining restrictions in other areas. Iran is likely to strongly oppose outside interference in its domestic legal system. These countries may therefore support development programs and government-led reforms while resisting revolutions they view as imposing foreign social or legal standards.

## **Non-aligned and developing states**

Non-aligned and developing states, like many African, Asian, and Latin countries, are likely to support greater opportunities and protections for women while emphasizing that reforms should respect national sovereignty and different levels of economic development.

They may prioritize issues such as girls' education, maternal healthcare, poverty reduction, economic independence, humanitarian assistance, and protection from violence. Some may be hesitant to support sanctions or aggressive international intervention against Middle Eastern governments.

## **Conflict-affected states**

Countries particularly concerned with conflicts in Gaza, Yemen, Syria, Iraq, and other unstable areas may emphasize the effects of war and displacement on women rather than concentrating primarily on domestic family law. Their proposed solutions could include humanitarian access, healthcare for women and girls, protection of refugees and displaced women, education during conflicts, and measures against gender-based violence. Political disagreements over the conflicts themselves further complicate a shared position.

The main divide delegates should watch is therefore not simply "pro-women's rights vs. anti-women's rights." Debate is more likely to center on universal human rights standards vs. national sovereignty, international accountability vs. domestic reform, and whether the committee should prioritize legal change, economic development, humanitarian protection, or some combination of these approaches.



## Previous UN and International Action

The United Nations and other International bodies have started the fight for women's rights. They have documented rights abuse, issued reports, and launched initiatives. The oldest is the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW), adopted in 1979. This international human rights treaty is sometimes referred to as an international bill of rights for women; it gave a clear definition of discrimination, calling it "any distinction, exclusion, or restriction made based on sex". It was ratified by 189 countries, meaning that they must end discrimination in all forms.

Governments must embody gender equality in their national constitutions or laws, authorities must abolish discriminatory laws and pass laws to prohibit discrimination, and public tribunals and institutions must be established to protect women effectively.

In the following years came the United Nations Declaration on the Elimination of Violence against Women. Here, it defines violence against women as any act of gender-based violence that causes or is likely to cause physical, sexual, or psychological harm or suffering. It addressed issues in the family and community.

In the family, it addressed issues like marital rape, FGM, and sexual abuse of female children. In the community, it covered rape, sexual abuse, sexual harassment, intimidation at work or school, trafficking, and forced prostitution. It calls for the equal rights of safety, liberty, integrity, and dignity for women, and urged countries to create legal, political, and social change to protect and prevent women from abuse.

### 189

States parties to CEDAW as of 2022 (IWRAP Asia Pacific)

### 38

Countries that rejected CEDAW's Article 29 dispute-enforcement clause

To comprehensively address women's rights abuses in the Middle East, the United Nations relies on key frameworks like UN Security Council Resolution 1325, which established the Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) agenda, the CEDAW treaty, and peacekeeping missions like UNIFIL in Lebanon that deploy gender advisors.

UN successes include guiding nations like Jordan, Iraq, and Lebanon to formalize national WPS action plans and successfully pressuring states to drop specific legal rollbacks. However, severe systemic failures persist due to the "reservation loophole," where Middle Eastern signatories heavily dilute CEDAW's power by exempting domestic family and nationality laws, leaving women excluded from formal peace negotiations and vulnerable in conflict zones like Yemen. The critical lesson learned from these actions is that top-down international mandates fail without deep partnerships with local civil society and religious scholars, proving that including women in formal peace processes is a prerequisite for long-term regional stability rather than an afterthought.

The United Nations, in partnership with the League of Arab States, recently enacted a specific policy known as the Regional Strategic Framework for Ending Violence Against Women and Girls in the Arab Region. This milestone roadmap establishes a shared accountability framework across 22 member states to directly reduce rights abuses. To achieve this, the policy systematically pushes for the strengthening of national legislation and provides survivors with standardized legal assistance and access to justice. It also mandates expanded public outreach to shift harmful cultural attitudes and establishes better mechanisms for tracking gender-based violence data. Ultimately, by turning high-level political commitments into enforceable national laws, this framework targets systemic loops that historically left Middle Eastern women unprotected in both private and digital spaces.

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## Key Issues to Address

Women's rights in the Middle East are shaped by interconnected political, economic, humanitarian, and environmental challenges. Conditions vary significantly between countries, meaning delegates must consider both regional patterns and individual national circumstances when developing solutions. Differences in political systems, religious and cultural traditions, levels of economic development, and exposure to armed conflict have created widely different experiences for women throughout the region.

Effective solutions, therefore, require delegates to consider how international human rights standards can be advanced while recognizing national sovereignty and differences among domestic legal systems.

### Legal equality and enforcement

Women in parts of the region continue to face unequal treatment under laws governing marriage, divorce, inheritance, child custody, movement, and political participation. The extent of these restrictions differs considerably among states, and some countries have introduced reforms expanding women's legal rights in recent years.

However, differences between written law and practical enforcement can limit the impact of these reforms. Delegates must consider how the international community can encourage greater legal protections while addressing concerns over national sovereignty, religious law, cultural traditions, and international human rights obligations. Possible areas of consideration include strengthening legal institutions, eliminating discriminatory provisions, and improving women's access to courts and other government services.

### Economic participation

Women's access to education has expanded considerably across much of the Middle East, but educational gains do not always translate into equal economic opportunities.

Barriers to employment, entrepreneurship, property ownership, transportation, childcare, and leadership positions can limit women's financial independence and ability to participate fully in national economies. Social expectations surrounding family and employment can create additional obstacles. Delegates should consider how governments and international organizations can bridge the divide between women's educational achievements and their participation in the workforce. Expanding affordable childcare, safe transportation, fair hiring practices, entrepreneurship opportunities, and pathways into leadership positions may play an important role in addressing these structural barriers.

## Conflict and displacement

Ongoing conflicts and displacement in areas including Gaza, Yemen, Syria, Sudan, and neighboring states have placed women and girls at increased risk of poverty, interrupted education, displacement, inadequate healthcare, and gender-based violence. Armed conflict can destroy schools and healthcare infrastructure, separate families, disrupt livelihoods, and weaken institutions responsible for protecting women's rights. Refugees and internally displaced women may face additional difficulties obtaining healthcare, legal documentation, safe housing, and employment.

Delegates must consider how women and girls can be protected during armed conflict while ensuring reliable access to humanitarian assistance, healthcare, education, shelter, and other basic necessities. Solutions must also consider how women can participate in humanitarian planning, peace negotiations, and post-conflict reconstruction rather than solely being treated as recipients of assistance.



A solidarity demonstration in Amsterdam following the death of Mahsa Amini, October 2022. Wikimedia Commons CC BY

## **Gender-based violence**

Domestic violence, harassment, trafficking, forced and child marriage, and other forms of gender-based violence (GBV) remain significant concerns in parts of the region. Although governments have taken different approaches to addressing these issues, weak enforcement mechanisms, social stigma, fear of retaliation, and limited trust in authorities can discourage survivors from reporting abuse or seeking assistance. Gaps or inconsistencies in national laws may also limit survivors' ability to obtain protection and hold perpetrators accountable.

Conflict and displacement can further increase vulnerability to trafficking, exploitation, and violence while weakening the institutions intended to respond to these crimes. Delegates should examine both legal reform and practical enforcement mechanisms, including safe and confidential reporting systems, access to shelters and legal assistance, survivor support services, stronger judicial institutions, and measures designed to address social attitudes that contribute to gender-based violence.

## **Political representation**

Although women have made major gains in education and public life, representation in political institutions and decision-making remains uneven across the region.

Restrictions caused by conflict, poverty, discrimination, displacement, or social expectations can also interfere with girls' ability to begin or complete their education. Limited representation can mean that women's experiences are not fully incorporated into laws, humanitarian programs, or peace processes that directly affect them. Increasing women's meaningful participation in government, diplomacy, peace negotiations, and policymaking is therefore an important consideration.

Delegates should examine not only the number of women represented in these institutions but also whether women have meaningful opportunities to influence decisions.

## **Environmental pressure**

Water scarcity, extreme heat, drought, food insecurity, and climate-related displacement can intensify existing inequalities. Women in poorer, rural, refugee, and conflict-affected communities may be particularly affected when families lose access to water, food, healthcare, education, or stable livelihoods.

Environmental pressures can also increase economic insecurity and displacement, potentially exposing women and girls to additional risks of exploitation or interrupted schooling. Delegates should consider how climate resilience and humanitarian planning can incorporate the needs and participation of women and girls, including through access to resources, sustainable employment opportunities, healthcare, education, and participation in environmental decision-making.

Ultimately, these challenges cannot be addressed independently. Legal inequality can restrict economic opportunities, economic dependence can increase vulnerability to violence, conflict can weaken access to justice and education, and environmental pressures can worsen existing humanitarian crises.

Delegates should therefore consider solutions that address these interconnected issues while balancing international human rights standards with national sovereignty, cultural and legal differences, and the practical realities faced by women throughout the region.

#### RESEARCH TIP

Ground your bloc's position in one country's law and one recent event. A delegate who can cite an actual reform, reservation, or protest speaks with more authority than one arguing in generalities.



## Guiding Questions

1. How can the UN balance state sovereignty with the enforcement of international human rights treaties, such as CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women), in nations that maintain structural legal reservations based on cultural or religious grounds?
2. What mechanisms can the international community deploy to ensure the protection and legal immunity of women's rights defenders and activists operating under repressive domestic regimes?
3. In what ways can member states reform personal status laws — specifically regarding male guardianship, inheritance inequality, and child marriage — while respecting regional cultural identities?
4. How can local judicial frameworks be strengthened to effectively criminalize domestic violence and marital rape, and what barriers prevent victims from safely accessing these legal protections?
5. How can humanitarian agencies ensure the unhindered delivery of gender-specific healthcare, including maternal and reproductive care, to women trapped in active conflict zones or under military blockades?
6. What comprehensive strategies should international bodies implement to protect internally displaced and refugee women from the heightened threats of human trafficking, exploitation, and gender-based violence in temporary camps?
7. What structural and economic policies are necessary to bridge the severe gender gap in workforce participation across the region, particularly regarding a woman's right to independent financial ownership and mobility?
8. How did the 1979 Islamic Revolution fundamentally alter the legal and social status of women in the region, and how can current international frameworks address the tension between modern human rights standards and the structural, institutional shifts that followed this historical turning point?

## Suggested Readings

Delegates are encouraged to consult the following sources to develop a deeper understanding of women's rights in the Middle East and to assist with country-specific research.

## **United Nations & International Sources**

- UN Women — Arab States — Regional overview of gender equality, political participation, economic empowerment, and violence against women.
- UN Women — GenTRACK Arab States — Country-specific statistics and indicators on economic empowerment, governance, violence against women, and gender equality.
- UN Women — Women, Peace and Security — Information on women's participation in peace processes and the impact of armed conflict on women and girls.
- UN Women — Women, Peace and Security in the Arab Region — Regional policy paper examining the Women, Peace and Security agenda in Arab states.
- UN Women — Social Norms, Religion and Muslim Family Laws in the Middle East and North Africa — A 2026 discussion paper examining the relationship between religion, family law, social norms, and gender equality.

## **Human Rights & Policy Analysis**

- Human Rights Watch — Middle East and North Africa — Current reporting on human-rights developments throughout the region, useful for researching individual countries.
- Council on Foreign Relations — Middle East and North Africa Timeline — Background on major political developments in the region, including women's rights movements and their relationship to broader regional politics.

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